strong connect with the youth, especially in urban India, a natural political constituency for Rahul to identify with. Yet, he chose to play safe. It was almost as if he was in power but still didn't know how to use it effectively. It was a tentative approach to politics that he needed to jettison if he wanted to be taken seriously as a leader.

~

On 19 January 2013, Rahul Gandhi was made the Congress vice president at a two-day Chintan Shivir (brainstorming) session organized in Jaipur. Congress workers were ecstatic. This was the moment for which they had been waiting for almost a decade—the official anointment of Rahul as the leader to take over the mantle from Sonia Gandhi. Large cut-outs of Rahul dotted the Jaipur skyline. '*Hamara Neta*, *Rahul Gandhi*' was the war cry. 'I can see Rajiv's dream being fulfilled today,' said an emotional Congressman, breaking down in front of the TV cameras. Asked whether this meant that Rahul would now be the Congress's prime ministerial candidate for the 2014 elections, the Congress spokesperson Janardhan Dwivedi quickly pressed the pause button. 'Any election-or campaign-related decisions will be taken at a later stage.'

The next day, Rahul made his maiden speech as Congress vice president. It was a passionate address. 'Last night each one of you congratulated me. My mother came to my room and she sat with me and she cried . . . because she understands that power so many people seek is actually a poison.' He added, 'My mother sees power as poison because she is not attached to it. The only antidote to this poison is for all of us to see what it really is and not become attached to it. We should not chase power for the attributes of power. We should only use it to empower the voices.'

The entire Congress leadership on stage and the party workers in the auditorium applauded. The '*ma–beta*' theme resonated strongly with a party of loyalists wedded to a family—the torch was being passed to another generation of Nehru–Gandhis. The speech, we were told, was spontaneous—this was Rahul Gandhi speaking from the heart. My own response as a